Attendance & Cancellation Policy

This policy applies to all services, including: Speech-Language Pathology (SLP), Occupational Therapy (OT), Physical Therapy (PT), Developmental Intervention (DI), Special Education (SE), Social – Emotional (S-E), and Mental Health (MH).

Purpose: Consistent attendance is essential for progress, continuity of care, and respectful use of provider time. This policy is designed to be **clear, supportive, and predictable** for families and providers.

We view attendance as a shared responsibility and address challenges early and collaboratively.

1. Attendance Expectations

- Therapy is most effective when sessions occur **consistently**.
- Families are expected to attend all scheduled appointments or provide adequate notice if they cannot attend. Adequate notice is considered more than 48 hours' notice.
- We encourage families to schedule appointments at times they can realistically maintain.

Consistency allows providers and families to track progress accurately, build therapeutic momentum, and use session time effectively.

2. Cancellation Definitions

- **Advance Cancellation:** Cancellation with **48 hours or more notice** before the scheduled appointment.
- **Late Cancellation:** Cancellation with **less than 24 hours' notice**.
- **No-Show:** Failure to attend an appointment without notice.

Late cancellations and no-shows significantly limit our ability to offer the time to another family.

3a. Acceptable Reasons for Cancellation

We understand that families have complex lives. Common acceptable reasons include:

- Acute illness
- Family emergencies
- Weather or unexpected transportation issues

We ask that families notify us **as soon as possible** when these situations arise.

3b. Missed Sessions

Clients with the following frequencies are allotted the corresponding number of missed sessions listed below within a rolling **six-month period** which is documented between each Annual or IFSP Review.

- **Four (4) total attendance incidents for WEEKLY sessions**
- **Two (2) total attendance incidents for BI-MONTHLY sessions**
- **One (1) total attendance incidents for MONTHLY sessions**

A **missed session** includes:

- No-shows
- Late cancellations (less than 24 hours' notice)
- Failure to complete a make-up session

Planned Absences

Cancellations made with **at least 48 hours' notice** for planned absences (e.g., vacations, school events) do not count as attendance incidents as long as the total number of missed sessions does not exceed four (4) within the six-month period. Make-up sessions for planned absences are not guaranteed and are scheduled only if availability allows.

Late Cancellations & No-Shows

Late cancellations and no-shows count as attendance incidents. To remain in good standing, these sessions **must be made up within 30 days**, subject to therapist availability.

*Completion of a make-up session does **not** remove the original attendance incident from the total count.*

Exceeding the Attendance Limit

If a client reaches or exceeds **four (4) attendance incidents** within the six-month period:

- The standing weekly appointment may be forfeited, and/or
- The client may be moved to same-week scheduling, and/or
- Services may be discontinued due to inconsistent attendance.

This policy is in place to support consistent care and therapeutic progress.

4. Make-Up Visits

- All missed visits (advance cancellations, late cancellations, or no-shows) are expected to be **made up within 30 days (1 month)** of the missed appointment when clinically appropriate and scheduling allows.
- Make-up visits help maintain progress and continuity of care.
- Make-up sessions are subject to provider availability and may not always occur in the same time slot as the original appointment.
- If a make-up visit cannot be scheduled within 30 days due to ongoing attendance barriers, the practice may review whether the current schedule or frequency remains appropriate.

5. Repeated Cancellations

When cancellations become frequent, it disrupts care and scheduling for everyone.

Patterns that may prompt outreach include:

- Multiple late cancellations or no-shows in a short period

- Repeated same-day cancellations
- Ongoing difficulty attending scheduled times

When patterns emerge, the practice will reach out to check in and problem-solve, review whether the scheduled time remains a good fit, and discuss alternative scheduling options or frequency.

This is a **supportive conversation**, not a disciplinary one.

6. After-School & High-Demand Appointment Times

After-school and early evening appointments are limited and in high demand these appointment times include anything between the hours of 3 pm to 8 pm Monday through Friday and Saturday or Sunday visits.

This helps ensure fair access for families who can attend consistently.

7. Provider Responsibilities

Providers commit to:

- Starting and ending sessions on time
- Communicating clearly about goals and expectations
- Checking in early if attendance concerns arise
- Partnering with families to reduce barriers

Providers are **not expected** to absorb repeated cancellations without support.

8. Practice Responsibilities

The practice commits to:

- Clear communication of this policy at intake and evaluation
- Reminder systems for appointments
- Early, respectful outreach when patterns develop
- Reviewing attendance data to improve systems

Our goal is to support both families and providers.

9. Possible Outcomes When Attendance Does Not Improve

If attendance challenges continue despite support:

- Appointments may be rescheduled to a different time or frequency
- Services may be paused until a consistent schedule is feasible
- In rare cases, discharge may occur due to inability to maintain attendance

Any changes will be discussed with the family in advance whenever possible.

10. A Shared Commitment

We believe therapy works best when families feel supported and informed, providers feel respected and effective, and expectations are clear and predictable.

We appreciate your partnership in maintaining consistent, meaningful care.

Family / Client Acknowledgment:

I have reviewed and understand the Attendance & Cancellation Policy to access early intervention services

with EMME for **[ClientName]**.

Client Signature	Date